USER MANUAL · APP VERSION 1.5.0

MPC Installer for Android

Install, update and remove VST plugins on an Akai MPC or Force from your phone: into the VST2 Plugins folder of MPC OS 3.10.1 and later, or the Synths folder of a modded MPC.

> **Use at your own risk.** Plugins from the catalog are community-provided and run as root on your device. They can crash MPC, lose unsaved work or, at worst, leave the device needing a reinstall of its OS. Save your project and back up first. This app is unofficial and not affiliated with or endorsed by Akai Professional.

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1. What you need

- An Android phone or tablet, Android 6.0 or later (the app is built for Android 16 and works on older versions).
- An Akai MPC OS standalone device (Force, MPC Live, Live II and Live III, One, X, XL and Key 61) that the app can reach over SSH:
  - **MPC OS 3.10.1 or later:** turn on **developer mode**, which starts the MPC's SSH server: Preferences, Info, then tap the version 3 times, the serial number twice and the firmware version once. Also turn on Preferences > Enhancements (Beta) > **Enable Enhancements** and **External Plugin Support**, or MPC hides third-party plugins.
  - **Older MPC OS:** a modded unit with root SSH access.

  The app refuses a device that is not an MPC OS device.
- The device's **IP address**, and its password if it has one. Your router assigns the address, so look it up on the device (network settings) or in your router each time.
- The phone and the MPC on the **same Wi-Fi network**.
- A **card, USB drive or SSD** in the MPC, formatted so it can hold symbolic links (ext4 is best). FAT, exFAT and NTFS drives are refused for plugins that need links.

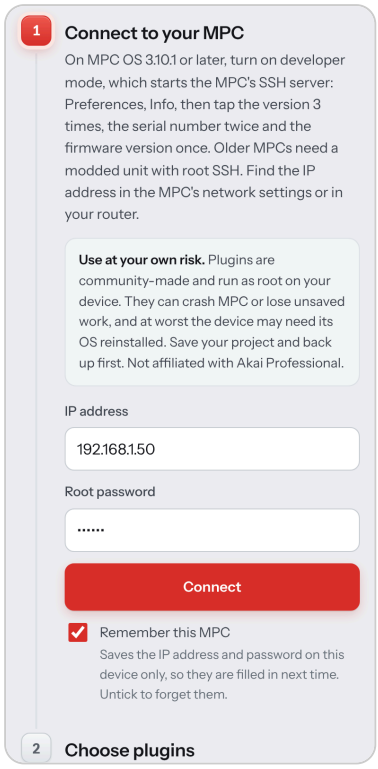
2. Install the app

1. Download `mpc-installer-<version>-android.apk` from the project's release page on GitHub, in your phone's browser.
2. Open the downloaded file. Android asks whether your browser (or Files app) may install apps: allow it for this one install.
3. Tap **Install**. If Play Protect shows a scan prompt, choose to scan or install anyway.
4. Open **MPC Installer**. The page appears inside the app; there is nothing else to set up.

> **Updating:** install the newer APK over the old one. It only works over an app signed with the same key, so use the APK from the same project release. If Android refuses, uninstall the old app first (nothing about your device is stored in it).

While the app is open it shows a small notification, "MPC Installer is running". That is intentional: it stops Android from cutting the app's Wi-Fi connection when you switch to another app in the middle of a copy.

3. Connect to your MPC



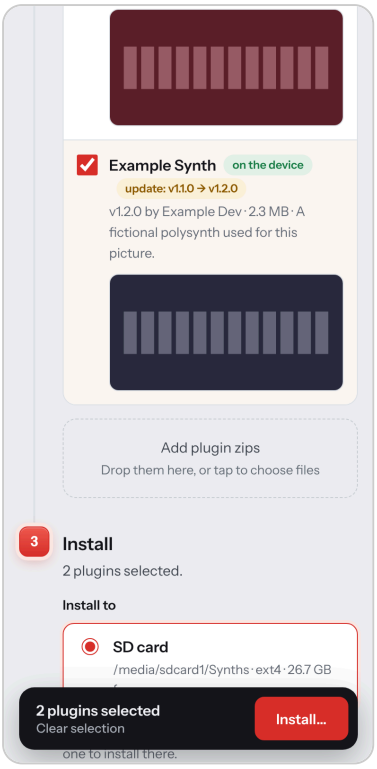
Step 1: connect

1. Type the MPC's IP address, for example `192.168.1.50`.
2. Type the password. Leave it empty only if the device has none. Keys are not used on a phone.
3. Tick **Remember this MPC** if you want the address and password filled in next time.
4. Tap **Connect**.

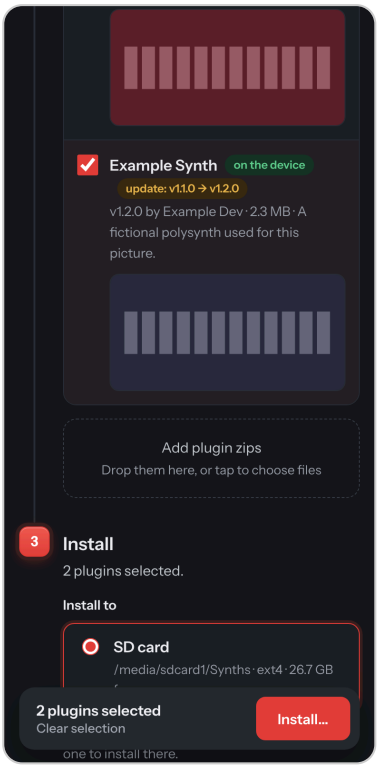
Remember this MPC saves the address and password on this phone only, inside the app's own storage, and only after they connected. Untick it to forget them straight away. Without it, nothing about your MPC is saved.

The app shows what it found: the MPC OS version, the plugins already on it, and the places plugins can go. It also shows the device's **key fingerprint**. If it changes between sessions for the same MPC, be careful: it can mean you are talking to a different device.

4. Choose plugins



Step 2: choose plugins (example data)



The same page in dark mode

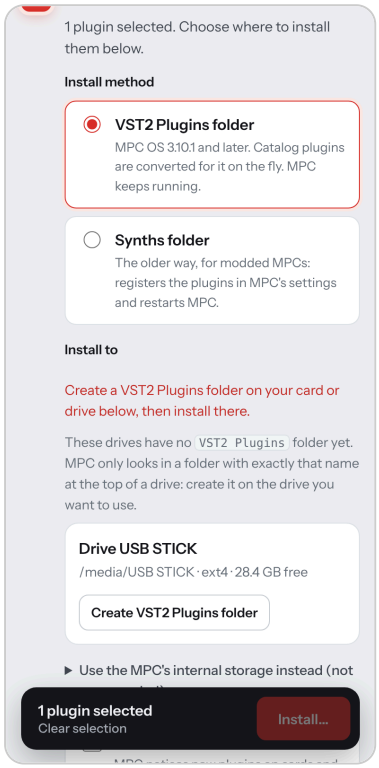
The list is the catalog's newest stable release of every downloadable plugin. You can browse it and tick plugins before connecting; connect to see which are already on your MPC and to install (the bottom bar's **Connect to install** takes you to step 1). Use the tabs (Instruments, MIDI, Effects, Addins, All), the search box, the developer filter, the sort and the "show" filter (not on the device, on the device, updates available, only the ones you ticked) to find what you want. Tick the plugins; what you ticked stays ticked while you filter. The list scrolls inside its own box, showing two or three plugins at a time, so the rest of the page is one short swipe below it. A bar at the bottom shows the count and an **Install** button.

You can also add your own release zips with **Add plugin zips**, which opens the phone's file picker. A zip is checked before it is accepted. Both kinds work: a release zip from the community catalog, and a zip made with inMusic's MPC Plugin Builder SDK (tagged *MPC OS 3.10.1 format*). Once a zip of yours has installed, the app drops it from the list; one that failed stays, so you can try again.

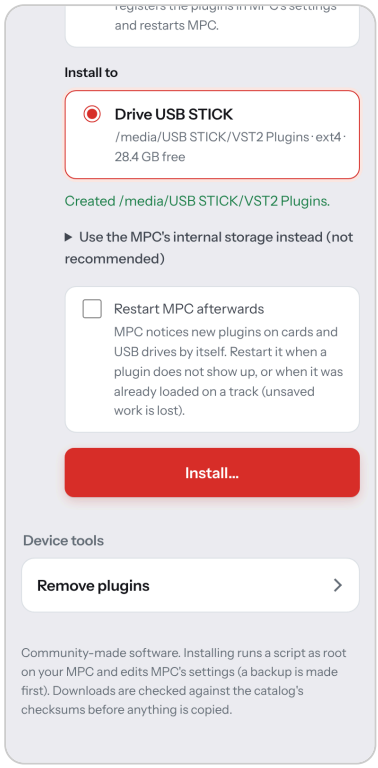
Plugins already on the device are flagged, and so are updates. Catalog downloads are checked against the catalog's checksums before anything is copied; a mismatch installs nothing.

5. Choose the method and where to install

MPC OS 3.10.1 brought support for third-party VST2 plugins: MPC loads them from a folder named `VST2 Plugins` at the top of any drive, in the format of inMusic's MPC Plugin Builder SDK. Older, modded MPCs load plugins from a `Synths` folder that has to be registered in MPC's settings. The app reads the MPC's version when it connects and picks the method for you. When both work, step 3 shows **Install method** so you can choose.



No VST2 Plugins folder yet (example data)



The folder made, ready to install

VST2 Plugins folder (MPC OS 3.10.1 and later)

Under **Install to** the app lists the cards, USB drives and SSDs that already have a `VST2 Plugins` folder. A drive without one is listed with a **Create VST2 Plugins folder** button: tap it on the drive you want, and the app makes the folder and selects it. Cards and USB drives come first; the MPC's internal storage is hidden behind *"Use the MPC's internal storage instead (not recommended)"*, for the same reason as below, and MPC only notices new plugins there when it starts.

Plugins from the catalog are made for the older Synths method, so the app **converts each one on the fly** before sending it, the way inMusic's own conversion tool does: the plugin's folder gets a `plugin.json` and a `version.xml`, loses the old installer's files, and is named *Manufacturer - VST - Name* as MPC expects. The plugin itself is not changed. The app also checks that its library fits your MPC (32-bit or 64-bit).

Restart MPC afterwards is off by default. MPC notices new plugins on cards and USB drives by itself; tick it when a plugin does not show up, or when it was already loaded on a track. A restart loses unsaved work.

Synths folder (modded MPCs)

Under **Install to** the app lists the drives it found under `/media` that already have a `Synths` folder, with the free space on each. Pick one. It is chosen for you when there is only one.

No Synths folder yet?

If a card or drive has none, the page lists it with a **Create Synths folder** button. Tap it and the app makes the folder on that drive, then selects it. Install stays off until a place is chosen; the app never installs somewhere you did not pick.

The internal drive

The internal drive is hidden behind *"Use the MPC's internal drive instead (not recommended)"*. It is the MPC's built-in flash storage (eMMC): every install, update and file a plugin writes adds wear, and if it fails the MPC itself needs repair. A card, USB drive or SSD is cheap to replace. Open that section and tick *"I understand"* only if you have no other choice.

Notes the app may show

- **Not in MPC's content locations:** a plugin's screen may not show until you add the folder in MPC's own settings.
- **Drive not in when MPC starts:** its plugins drop out of the plugin list until you register them again (section 8).
- **noexec:** Linux can mount a drive with or without permission to run programs, and the same drive can be mounted either way at different times. The app only notes it and still installs. If a plugin shows only "Load Plugin" in MPC afterwards, restart the MPC with the drive in and register the folders.

Under the choices there is a tick box, on by default: **after installing, register every plugin folder on the device with MPC**. This is built into the app, so nothing has to be on the MPC. It adds missing entries to MPC's plugin list, drops broken ones, and backs up MPC's settings first.

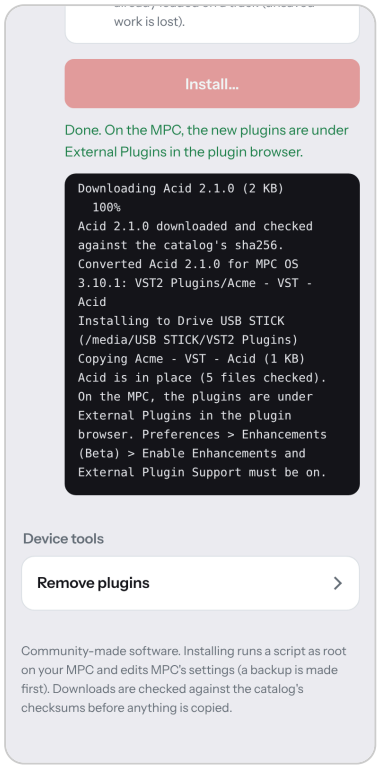
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6. Install

With the VST2 Plugins folder: tap **Install...**, check the summary and tap **Install**. MPC keeps running. Each plugin is converted if needed, copied to a hidden staging folder on the drive, moved into `VST2 Plugins` (an older copy is replaced) and its files are checked. A plugin that fails does not stop the others. When it says Done, open the plugin browser on the MPC: the plugins are under **External Plugins**.

With the Synths folder:

1. Tap **Install…** and read the summary: what will be installed, where, and how many times MPC restarts (usually once).
2. **Save your project on the MPC first.** MPC is stopped and started again, and anything unsaved is lost.
3. Tap **Install**. The page scrolls down by itself to the progress area.
4. Keep the app open until it says *"Done. MPC is starting again: the new plugins are in the plugin list."*
5. Plugins that installed are unticked by themselves, so the next install starts fresh. One that failed stays ticked, to try again.



The progress area after a finished install (example data)

The app copies every package to a private folder on the device, stops MPC once, runs each plugin's installer, registers the plugin folders, starts MPC once and removes the temporary copies. MPC is started again even if something fails, and nothing after a failing plugin is installed.

If the connection drops

Phones sometimes cut a connection (Wi-Fi sleep, a VPN, switching apps). If it drops during the copy, the app reconnects, checks that the device's key is unchanged, and copies once more. Until every copy has finished, nothing is installed and MPC has not been stopped.

7. Remove plugins, and move old ones to VST2 Plugins

Plugins still in a Synths folder (MPC OS 3.10.1+)

If your MPC was set up the old way and now runs MPC OS 3.10.1 or later, plugins you installed before are still in a `Synths` folder. The app finds them when it connects (the connection summary says how many) and lists them under **Device tools** in **Move old plugins to VST2 Plugins**.

1. Make sure a VST2 Plugins folder is chosen under **Install to** in step 3 (create one first if needed). That is where they go.
2. Open **Move old plugins to VST2 Plugins**, tick the plugins and tap **Move to VST2 Plugins...**, then **Move**.
3. Each plugin is converted on the MPC itself: its folder is copied with everything in it, your own files included, gets the `plugin.json` and `version.xml` MPC 3.10.1 needs, and every file is compared with the original before the copy is put in place. MPC keeps running. One that fails (for example a 64-bit library on a 32-bit MPC) does not stop the others, and its old folder is untouched.
4. When it is done, the app asks **Delete the old copies? Delete old copies** removes the old folders of the plugins that moved, and their entries in MPC's old plugin list (MPC's settings are backed up first, and MPC restarts once: save your project). **Keep them** leaves them, but MPC may then list a plugin twice.

Removing

VST2 Plugins folder: the list shows the plugins in the VST2 Plugins folders. Removing one deletes its whole folder, including any samples or other files it came with. MPC keeps running; take the plugin off any track that uses it first.

Synths folder:

Under **Device tools**, open **Remove plugins**. It lists the plugin folders on the device. Tick the ones to remove and tap **Remove...**. The app stops MPC once, backs up MPC's settings, takes the plugin out of the plugin list, deletes the plugin's folder and starts MPC again.

- **Your own files are kept:** ROMs, kits and dumps that the plugin's manifest names as user data are not deleted.
- A plugin the app cannot identify (not from the catalog and not from a zip you added in this session) is listed but cannot be removed from here, because the app cannot tell which files in the folder are yours. Add its release zip to manage it, or remove it by hand.
- Addins (libraries MPC loads at start-up) are listed last. Removing one runs its own uninstaller, which also takes it out of MPC's start-up list.

8. Something missing from the plugin list? (Synths folder)

Installing already registers its plugins, so most people never need this box. Open it under **Device tools** when a plugin folder is on the device but MPC does not show it. Typical causes: you copied a folder in by hand, or MPC forgot it because a card was out when it started.

The box shows how many folders are waiting. Tap **Register…**: the app adds the missing entries, drops entries whose plugin file is gone, leaves everything else alone, backs up MPC's settings first, and restarts MPC once.

9. Clean up old backups (Synths folder)

Every install, removal and registering leaves a copy of MPC's settings file (`MPC.settings.bak-…`) on the device. They are small but nothing deletes them. Under **Device tools**, open **Clean up old backups**, choose how many of the newest to keep (10 is a good number) and tap **Delete older backups…**. The newest backup is never deleted, and MPC is not restarted.

10. Dark mode and banners

- **Appearance:** the three buttons at the top right choose *Match the system* (half-filled circle), *Light* (sun) or *Dark* (moon). The phone's status and navigation bars follow your choice, and the app remembers it.
- **Banners:** each catalog plugin shows its banner picture in the list. The pictures come from the web, so turn them off with **Show banners** if you are on mobile data. This is remembered too.

11. Troubleshooting

You see	Try this
Connect times out	Wrong IP, the MPC is asleep, or the phone is on another network (mobile data, guest Wi-Fi). Look the IP up again.
Permission denied, or Connect times out on MPC OS 3.10.1+	Wrong password, or developer mode is off: turn it on again (Preferences, Info: the version 3 times, the serial number twice, the firmware version once). On older firmware, the unit needs root SSH access (a modded MPC).
"Not an MPC OS device"	The address belongs to another computer. Check the IP.
Install is greyed out	No install location is chosen. Pick a drive, or create a Synths folder on one (section 5).
"software caused connection abort"	The phone cut the connection. The app reconnects and retries once by itself. If it still fails, stay in the app, keep the screen on, and try again. Nothing is installed after a failed copy.
A plugin is not in MPC's browser (MPC OS 3.10.1+)	Check Preferences > Enhancements (Beta): Enable Enhancements and External Plugin Support must both be on. Look under External Plugins. If it is still missing, install again with Restart MPC afterwards ticked.
"needs arm64" or "built for arm32"	The plugin's library does not fit your MPC: 64-bit MPCs (Live III, XL) need a 64-bit build. Get the other zip, or ask its author for one.
Plugin only shows "Load Plugin"	Restart the MPC with the drive in, then register the folders (section 8). The drive may have been mounted noexec at that moment.
Plugin screen is empty	The folder is not one of MPC's content locations, or the plugin has no skin for your MPC OS version (MPC OS 2.x versus 3.x).
Not enough room, or drive refused	Free space on the drive, or use an ext4 drive: FAT, exFAT and NTFS cannot hold symbolic links.
Catalog does not load	The phone has no internet. The catalog and plugin downloads need it; the MPC does not.
Play Protect blocks the APK	Use the APK from the project release (it targets current Android). Choose *More details* then *Install anyway* if it still asks.

12. Good to know

- Nothing about your MPC (address, password) is stored on the phone unless you tick **Remember this MPC**; then only the address and password are kept, in the app's own storage, until you untick it.
- Quitting the app while an install is running can leave it half done. The back button asks before quitting.
- Installing runs a script as root on the MPC and edits MPC's plugin settings; a backup is always made first.
- The app does not offer device patches (such as the 16-pad drum layout). They change Akai's own program and are not for a phone app. If you want one, run its script over SSH as its own guide says.
- Developers: build instructions and internals are in `tools/android/README.md`. The app is the desktop installer (`tools/desktop`) in an Android wrapper, so the desktop and Android apps share the same page and behaviour.

Screens shown use invented example plugins and an example IP address. This manual describes version 1.5.0. Tested by the author on a real MPC from an Android phone; still test a first install with a saved project.